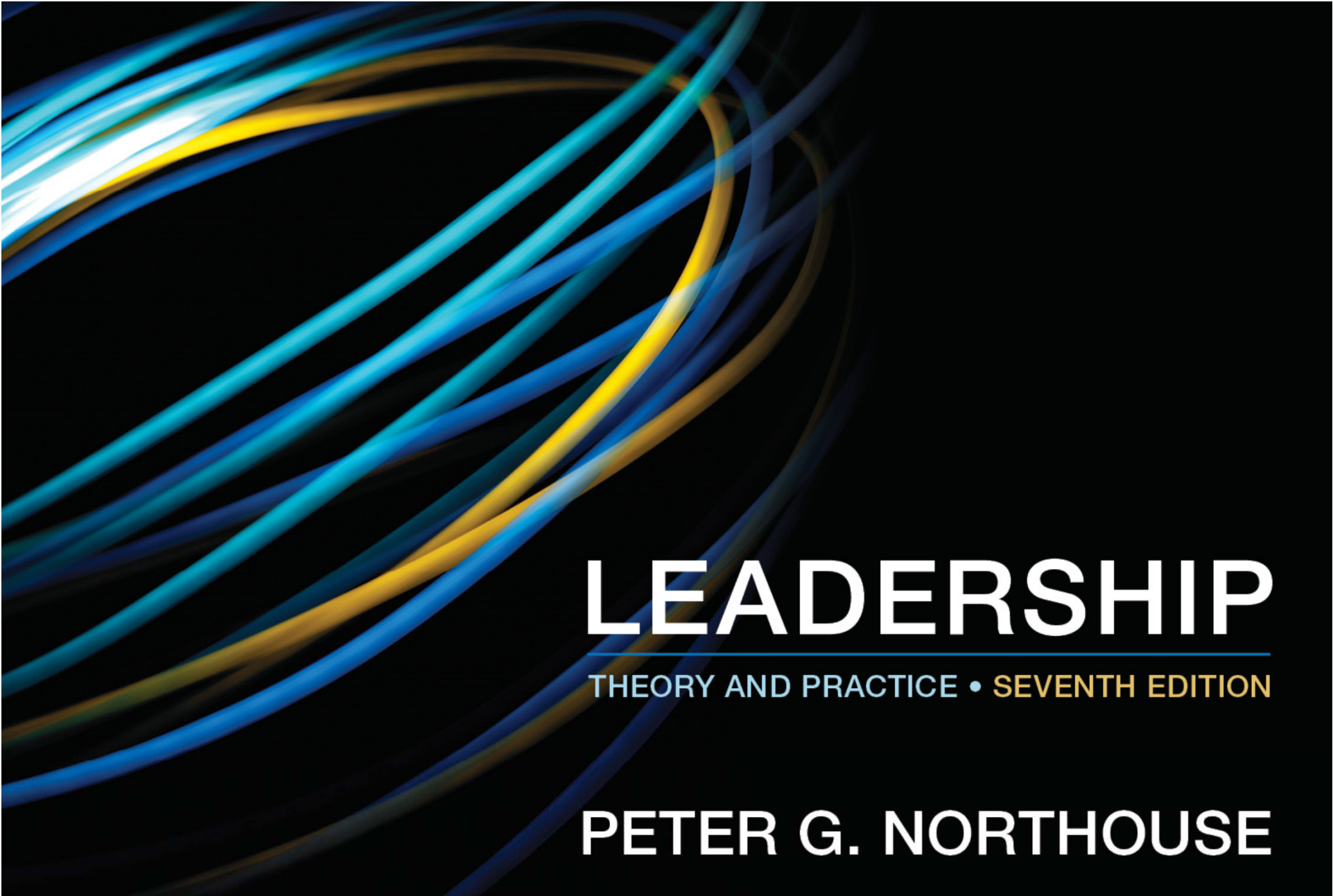




LEADERSHIP

THEORY AND PRACTICE • SEVENTH EDITION

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Chapter 6: Path-Goal Theory

Overview

- ✦ Path–Goal Theory Perspective
- ✦ Conditions of Leadership Motivation
- ✦ Leader Behaviors & Follower Characteristics
- ✦ Task Characteristics
- ✦ How Does PGT Work?

Path–Goal Theory (House, 1971)

Description

Definition

- ✦ Path–goal theory centers on how leaders motivate followers to accomplish designated goals
- ✦ Emphasizes the relationship between
 - ✦ the leader's style
 - ✦ the characteristics of the followers
 - ✦ the work setting

Path–Goal Theory (House, 1971)

Description

Perspective

- ✦ Goal - To enhance employee performance and satisfaction by focusing on employee motivation
- ✦ Motivational Principles (based on Expectancy Theory) - Followers will be motivated if they believe
 - ✦ they are capable of performing their work
 - ✦ that their efforts will result in a certain outcome
 - ✦ that the payoffs for doing their work are worthwhile

Challenge to Leader

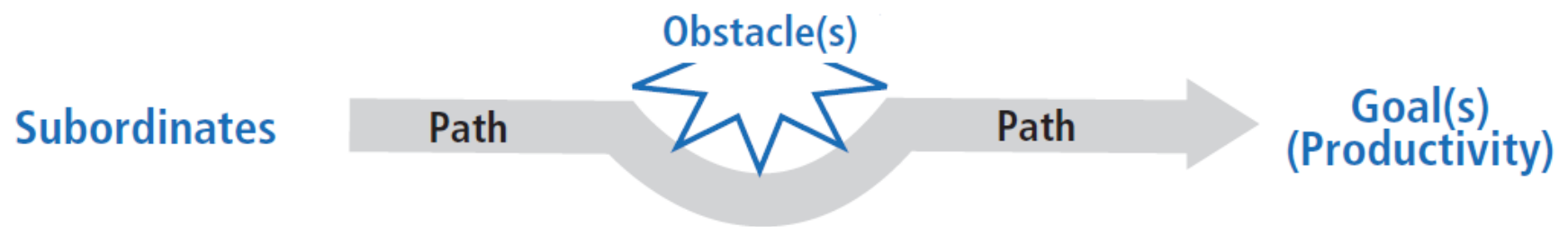
- ✦ Use a leadership style that best meets followers' motivational needs
- ✦ choose behaviors that complement or supplement what is missing in the work setting
- ✦ enhance goal attainment by providing information or rewards
- ✦ provide followers with the elements they need to reach their goals

Conditions of Leadership Motivation

Leadership generates motivation when

- ✦ It increases the ***number*** and ***kinds*** of payoffs followers receive from their work
- ✦ Makes the path to the goal ***clear*** and easy to travel through with ***coaching*** and ***direction***
- ✦ Removes ***obstacles*** and roadblocks to attaining the goal
- ✦ Makes the work itself more personally ***satisfying***

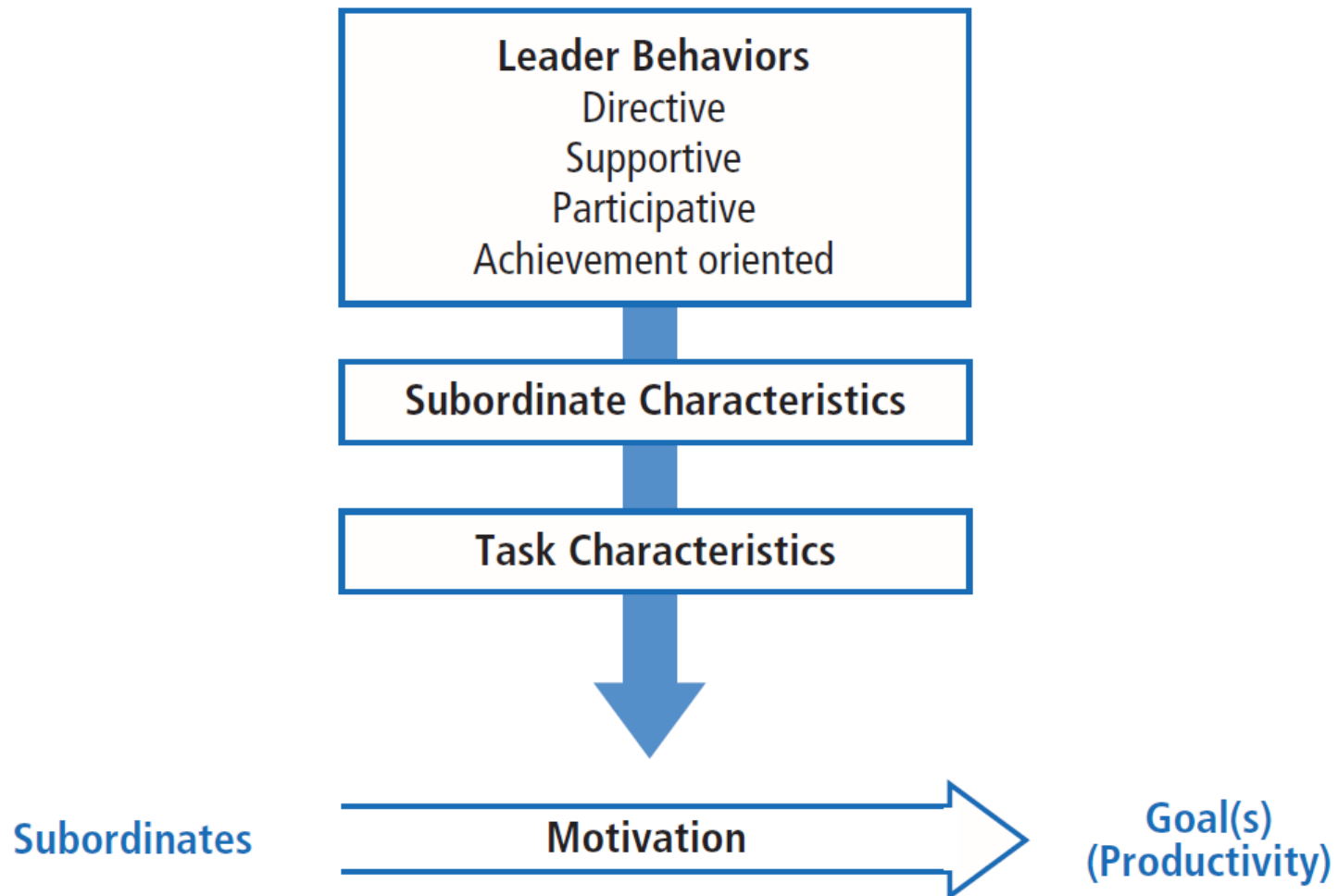
Figure 6.1 The Basic Idea Behind Path–Goal Theory



Path–Goal Leadership

- Defines goals
- Clarifies path
- Removes obstacles
- Provides support

Figure 6.2 Major Components of Path–Goal Theory



Leader Behaviors

Directive Leadership

- ✦ Leader who gives followers task instruction including:
 - ✦ What is expected of them
 - ✦ How task is to be done
 - ✦ Timeline for task completion
 - ✦ Clear standards of performance
 - ✦ Clear rules & regulations

Leader Behaviors

Supportive Leadership

Leader who is friendly and approachable:

- ✦ Attending to well-being & human needs of followers
- ✦ Using supportive behavior to make work environment pleasant
- ✦ Treating followers as equals & giving them respect for their status

Leader Behaviors

Participative Leadership

- ✦ Leader who invites followers to share in the decision making:
- ✦ Consults with followers
- ✦ Seeks their ideas & opinions
- ✦ Integrates their input into group/organizational decisions

Leader Behaviors

Achievement-Oriented Leadership

- ✦ Leader who challenges followers to perform work at the highest level possible:
- ✦ Establishes a high standard of excellence for subordinates
- ✦ Seeks continuous improvement
- ✦ Demonstrates a high degree of confidence in followers' ability to establish & achieve challenging goals

Follower Characteristics

Strong need for affiliation

- ✦ Friendly and concerned leadership is a source of satisfaction
- ✦ **Supportive Leadership**

Preference for Structure

- ✦ Dogmatic & authoritarian
 - Leadership provides psychological structure, task clarity, & greater sense of certainty in work setting
- ✦ **Directive Leadership**

Follower Characteristics

Desire for Control

Internal locus of control

- ✦ Leadership that allows followers to feel in charge of their work & makes them an integral part of the decision-making process
- ✦ **Participative Leadership**

External locus of control

- ✦ Leadership that parallels followers' feelings that outside forces control their circumstances
- ✦ **Directive Leadership**

Follower Characteristics

Perception of their own ability – specific task

- ✦ As perception of ability and competence goes up, need for highly directive leadership goes down
- ✦ Directive leadership may become redundant, possibly excessively controlling

Task Characteristics

Components

- ✦ Design of followers' task
- ✦ Organization's formal authority system
- ✦ Primary work group of followers

Task Characteristics

Task Situations Requiring Leader Involvement

- ✦ **Unclear and ambiguous** - Leader needs to provide structure
- ✦ **Highly repetitive** - Leader needs to provide support to maintain follower motivation
- ✦ **Weak formal authority** - If formal authority system is weak, the leader needs to assist followers by making rules and work requirements clear
- ✦ **Nonsupportive/weak group norms** - Leader needs to help build cohesiveness and role responsibility

Task Characteristics

Obstacles

- ✦ **Anything in the work setting that gets in the way of followers**
 - ✦ They create excessive uncertainties, frustrations, or threats for followers
 - ✦ **Leader's responsibility is to help followers by**
 - ✦ Removing the obstacles
 - ✦ Helping followers around them
- ✦ **Assisting with obstacles will increase**
 - ✦ Followers' expectations to complete the task
 - ✦ Their sense of job satisfaction

How Does the Path–Goal Theory Work?

- ✦ **Focus of Path–Goal Theory**
- ✦ **Strengths**
- ✦ **Criticisms**
- ✦ **Application**

How Does the Path–Goal Theory Work?

- ✦ The leader's job is to help followers reach their goals by directing, guiding, and coaching them along the way
- ✦ Leaders must evaluate task and follower characteristics and adapt leadership style to these
- ✦ The theory suggests which style is most appropriate for specific characteristics

Path–Goal Theory Approach

Focus

- ✦ Path–goal theory is a complex but also pragmatic approach
- ✦ Leaders should choose a leadership style that best fits the needs of followers and their work

Overall Scope

- ✦ Path–goal theory provides a set of ***assumptions*** about how different leadership styles will interact with follower characteristics and the work situation to affect employee motivation

Table 6.1 Path–Goal Theory: How It Works

Leadership Behavior	Follower Characteristics	Task Characteristics
Directive Provides guidance and psychological structure	Dogmatic Authoritarian	Ambiguous Unclear rules Complex
Supportive Provides nurturance	Unsatisfied Need affiliation Need human touch	Repetitive Unchallenging Mundane
Participative Provides involvement	Autonomous Need for control Need for clarity	Ambiguous Unclear Unstructured
Achievement Oriented Provides challenges	High expectations Need to excel	Ambiguous Challenging Complex

Strengths

- ✦ **Useful theoretical framework.** Path–goal theory is a useful theoretical framework for understanding how various leadership behaviors affect the satisfaction of followers and their work performance.
- ✦ **Integrates motivation.** Path–goal theory attempts to integrate the motivation principles of expectancy theory into a theory of leadership.
- ✦ **Practical model.** Path–goal theory provides a practical model that underscores and highlights the important ways leaders help followers.

Criticisms

- ✦ Interpreting the meaning of the theory can be confusing because it is so complex and incorporates so many different aspects of leadership; consequently, it is difficult to implement.
- ✦ Empirical research studies have demonstrated only partial support for path–goal theory.
- ✦ It fails to adequately explain the relationship between leadership behavior and worker motivation.
- ✦ The path–goal theory approach treats leadership as a one-way event in which the leader affects the follower.

Application

- ✦ PGT offers valuable insights that can be applied in ongoing settings to improve one's leadership.
- ✦ Informs leaders about when to be directive, supportive, participative, or achievement oriented.
- ✦ The principles of PGT can be employed by leaders at all organizational levels and for all types of tasks.